

Halleck because one-third of his force was incapacitated. When the Union Army took the city in June, Halleck called off his invasion for the same reason.

Dysentery, diarrhea, typhoid, and malaria—all caused by poor sanitation—were rampant in the camps. Measles, smallpox, and common colds were passed around by the men, and pneumonia developed quickly among green troops exposed to the elements. Quinine was available to treat malaria and most armies routinely inoculated against smallpox, but outbreaks of both diseases occurred regularly. Opium, castor oil, and Epsom salts were prescribed to combat diarrhea and dysentery.

In most cases, the cure was bed rest, but rest was difficult for campaigning soldiers or those in the rigors of initial training. Many came to call the first few months of service “the hardening,” as they struggled to condition themselves and their immune systems to army life. Thousands could not and died before they ever left camp.

Union surgeon W. W. Keen described caring for the wounded: “We operated in old blood-stained and often pus-stained coats [with] disinfected hands ... We used undisinfected instruments from undisinfected plush-lined cases ... and used marine sponges which had been used in prior pus cases and had been only washed in tap water.”